

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cybersecurity English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For security analysts, SOC staff, incident responders, security engineers, GRC specialists, identity teams, vulnerability managers, and security leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Security Triage and Alert Investigation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

02 Incident Response and Containment

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

03 Vulnerability Management

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

04 Identity, Access, and Least Privilege

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

05 Threat Modeling and Secure Design

Clarify missing information before responding.

06 Governance, Risk, and Compliance

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

07 Security Awareness and Phishing

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

08 Executive Risk Briefings

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Security Triage and Alert Investigation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A monitoring tool raises an alert about a privileged account. The analyst has not determined whether the activity is authorized.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: SIEM, alert, false positive, privileged account.

Model response

The alert indicates activity that needs investigation. It does not by itself establish a compromise. I'll record the observed event and the questions needed to determine its significance.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. An alert is not confirmed account misuse - Fictional security triage using the lesson case: an alert concerns a privileged account, and authorization has not been established.
2. A travel explanation needs a matched timestamp - Fictional alert review: an account shows a login from an unfamiliar location; the employee mentioned travel, but dates have not been matched.

3. Many alerts may describe one event - Fictional monitoring review: three SIEM alerts reference the same event identifier; their relationship has not been assessed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An administrator recognizes the command name

A fictional privileged-account alert contains a familiar maintenance command name. The administrator recognizes it, but execution time and authorization have not been verified. Discuss what the recognition establishes and what remains open.

Role A: Security analyst: distinguish familiarity from verified authorization.

Role B: System administrator: provide context without requesting automatic closure.

Possible opening: The command name is familiar, but we still need to match this execution to authorized maintenance.

Success checks

- Preserve the observed alert details.
- Do not treat recognition as proof of authorization.
- Agree a controlled verification step.

Add a complication: A manager asks you to mark the alert false positive before the record is checked.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Incident Response and Containment

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

A response team receives a suspected incident. The initial report contains a timestamp and affected service but no confirmed cause.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: incident, containment, ransomware, forensics.

Model response

The report identifies the affected service and timestamp; the cause is unconfirmed. Please acknowledge the handoff and use the response process to coordinate investigation and any containment decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. Handoff with a timestamp, not a confirmed cause - Separate fictional response handoff: a suspected incident was reported at 09:10 UTC on 8 September 2026 for service DOC-7. The cause and containment status are unconfirmed.

2. A containment request is not a completed action - Fictional incident handoff: a request to isolate a workstation was submitted to authorized responders, but no execution confirmation has arrived.

3. The handoff crosses a time-zone boundary - Fictional incident transfer: a report says 09:10 without a time zone; the receiving team works in another region, and the source log is available.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two asset names may refer to one workstation

A fictional suspected-incident report names workstation LAB-4, while an isolation request names asset 204. Their relationship is unverified. Hand over the mismatch without directing action against either asset.

Role A: Triage analyst: identify the two recorded names and missing mapping.

Role B: Incident coordinator: confirm receipt and route asset verification to the authorized responder.

Possible opening: The report and request use different asset names; we have not verified that they identify the same workstation.

Success checks

- Preserve both identifiers accurately.
- Avoid claiming containment or identity is confirmed.
- Agree a verified asset-mapping handoff.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests assuming the names match to save time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Vulnerability Management

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

Two vulnerabilities have similar severity scores, but one affects an exposed service and the other an isolated test system.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: CVE, CVSS, exploitability, compensating control.

Model response

The scores are similar, but exposure and operational context differ. Let's compare those factors and the available evidence before presenting a remediation priority to the responsible team.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Similar severity, different exposure - Fictional vulnerability prioritization using the lesson case: similar severity scores affect an exposed service and an isolated test system.
2. A scanner finding needs applicability checks - Fictional assessment: a scanner flags the same vulnerability identifier on two servers; installed component and version evidence is incomplete for one.

3. Patch availability and service disruption - Fictional remediation planning: two affected services have proposed patches; one has a tested maintenance plan, while the other's recovery plan is unverified.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The unused service is still running

A fictional system owner calls a vulnerable service unused, but monitoring shows it is running. Network exposure and business dependency are unknown. Compare the claim with the evidence and request the information needed for prioritization.

Role A: Vulnerability analyst: explain why unused is not a verified risk classification.

Role B: System owner: acknowledge unknown dependencies and help locate evidence.

Possible opening: The service is running; we still need to verify exposure and dependencies before prioritizing its remediation.

Success checks

- Separate reported use from verified exposure.
- Compare security and operational criteria.
- Route the decision without directing an unreviewed service shutdown.

Add a complication: The owner asks you to treat no recent support tickets as proof that disabling it has no impact.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Identity, Access, and Least Privilege

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A vendor requests a shared privileged account for support. The organization has a controlled access-review process.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: IAM, least privilege, MFA, RBAC.

Model response

Could you specify the tasks, users, and access period required? We'll submit the request through the access-review process so the appropriate scope and accountability can be assessed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. A - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Request named, reviewed vendor access - Fictional access discussion using the lesson case: a vendor requests a shared privileged account, and the organization has a controlled access-review process.
2. A temporary role without an end date - Fictional access request: an employee needs temporary reporting access for a project, but the request does not specify tasks or duration.

3. Check task needs before copying access - Fictional access review: a manager proposes copying a departing colleague's role for a replacement; task equivalence has not been checked.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | View access for a one-hour demonstration

A fictional trainer needs to demonstrate a report for one hour. The request asks for editing rights, although no editing task is specified. The session is next week. Request clarification through access review without granting permissions.

Role A: IAM analyst: ask what demonstration actions require editing.

Role B: Trainer: explain the intended viewing task and revise the requested scope.

Possible opening: Could you clarify which demonstration task needs editing rights rather than report viewing?

Success checks

- Connect permissions to stated tasks.
- Specify purpose and requested duration.
- Keep approval with the access owner.

Add a complication: The trainer asks for broad access in case an unplanned task appears.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Threat Modeling and Secure Design

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A threat-model discussion lists technologies but does not identify the data flows or trust boundaries.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: threat model, attack surface, trust boundary, abuse case.

Model response

Which data crosses each boundary, and who can interact with it? Let's map those flows so the discussion connects possible threats to the actual design.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. List the data flows, not only technologies - Fictional threat-model review using the lesson case: a diagram lists technologies but does not identify data flows or trust boundaries.
2. Who can send the webhook? - Fictional secure-design discussion: a service receives partner webhooks, but sender verification and receiving actions are undocumented.
3. An internal upload still crosses a boundary - Fictional document-tool design: employees upload files to a shared processing service; file origins and processing permissions have not been mapped.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A report link leaves the application

A fictional application sends users to an external report viewer. The design names the viewer but does not say which identifiers appear in the link or who can open it. Clarify the data flow and access boundary.

Role A: Security reviewer: ask about link contents, destination, and access checks.

Role B: Product architect: distinguish known routing from undocumented authorization.

Possible opening: Which information leaves our application in that report link, and who can use it at the destination?

Success checks

- Identify the actual outgoing data question.
- Do not equate reputation with verified authorization.
- Agree who will confirm destination access behavior.

Add a complication: A colleague says the viewer is reputable, so no boundary review is needed.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Governance, Risk, and Compliance

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

An audit action is marked closed because a policy was written. Evidence that the control operates is still missing.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: control, audit evidence, risk acceptance, remediation.

Model response

The policy is complete, but evidence of operation is still outstanding. I'll distinguish the documented design from implementation evidence before we report the action's status.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. B - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. Written policy, missing operating evidence - Fictional audit review using the lesson case: an action is marked closed because a policy exists, but evidence that the control operates is missing.
2. A screenshot without a review period - Fictional control assessment: a current settings screenshot is available, but the audit asks about operation over the previous quarter.

3. Risk acceptance is requested, not approved - Fictional governance update: remediation is deferred in a proposal, and a risk-acceptance request has been submitted but not approved.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Training invitations sent; completion unverified

A fictional audit action requires reviewed evidence of staff training completion. Invitations were sent to 20 staff, but completion records have not been checked. Explain what is complete and what remains pending.

Role A: Control owner: report invitations sent without claiming completion.

Role B: Audit coordinator: request the relevant completion evidence and review scope.

Possible opening: The invitations went to twenty staff, but completion evidence has not yet been checked.

Success checks

- Separate assignment from completion.
- Do not infer attendance or understanding from silence.
- Agree evidence collection and review ownership.

Add a complication: A manager says no complaints about the invitation proves everyone completed training.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Security Awareness and Phishing

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A staff member reports a suspicious message and worries about being blamed. The report has not yet been assessed.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: phishing, social engineering, reporting culture, security awareness.

Model response

Thank you for reporting it. Please use the designated channel to share the relevant details. We'll focus on assessing the message and the next steps rather than making assumptions about blame.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. A - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. C - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 · Conversations

1. Thank the reporter without declaring a verdict - Fictional awareness exchange using the lesson case: an employee reports a suspicious message and fears blame; the message is unassessed.
2. A simulation result should not become a public accusation - Fictional awareness program: a draft summary names an employee as careless after one training simulation interaction; the interaction details have not been

reviewed.

3. Correcting an all-clear before assessment - Fictional service-desk exchange: a suspicious message was called safe because it displayed a familiar sender name; assessment is still pending.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The employee reported late

A fictional employee reports a suspicious message the next morning and says they delayed because a previous response felt blaming. The message and any effect are unassessed. Repair the communication and encourage factual reporting.

Role A: Security awareness lead: acknowledge the discouraging earlier response without promising an outcome.

Role B: Team administrator: explain the reporting delay and ask what information to provide.

Possible opening: I'm sorry the earlier response discouraged you; thank you for bringing this report to us now.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the communication problem.
- Avoid assumptions about compromise or blame.
- Guide the factual report into the established channel.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to focus the conversation on punishment before assessing the message.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Executive Risk Briefings

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A budget proposal describes many technical weaknesses but never explains their possible business effects.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: residual risk, threat actor, maturity, investment ask.

Model response

I'll connect each issue to the affected service, plausible consequence, and proposed response. That will help leaders compare the investment request with the risk it is intended to address.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Translate weaknesses into possible business effects - Separate fictional executive briefing: restoration of the booking service has not been tested. A proposed restoration exercise needs staff time; potential outage duration and the exercise's benefit are unverified.

2. A capability score is not incident probability - Fictional executive review: a security maturity assessment gives a low documentation score; a leader interprets it as a measured probability of attack.

3. Funding a control does not eliminate exposure - Fictional budget discussion: a proposed monitoring improvement could shorten detection work, but effect estimates and remaining gaps are not yet verified.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A tabletop exercise is not a restored service

A fictional response team completed a discussion-based exercise. No live service restoration was performed or measured. An executive wants to announce proven rapid recovery. Explain the exercise result and the remaining evidence gap.

Role A: Security manager: explain what the exercise practiced.

Role B: Executive sponsor: ask what would support a recovery-capability claim.

Possible opening: The exercise practiced decisions and coordination; it did not measure restoration of a live service.

Success checks

- Distinguish discussion practice from measured restoration.
- Do not invent a recovery-time claim.
- Identify the next evidence question and remaining uncertainty.

Add a complication: The sponsor asks for a recovery-time figure derived from the meeting length.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.